ACA X · AI FOR PRODUCT MANAGERS

Get Ready: Your AI Setup Guide

Everything you need installed **before Session 2**, so we spend class building, not installing. Follow it top to bottom. No technical experience needed. If you can install a normal app, you can do this.

~30 min	4 steps	$20/mo	Mac + Win
TOTAL TIME	TO BE READY	CLAUDE PRO (REQUIRED)	BOTH COVERED

Before you start, have these ready:

- Your own laptop (Mac or Windows) that you can install apps on. A personal laptop is best. Work laptops sometimes block installs.
- A payment card for the Claude Pro subscription (about $20/month, cancel anytime).
- About 30 quiet minutes. Do this on a decent internet connection.
- Stuck at any point? Message me (contact at the bottom). Do not skip Session 2 setup because of a snag.

THE 4 STEPS

1 Create your Claude account and get Pro

REQUIRED

This is the one thing that costs money, and it is required. One account powers everything we use.

1. Go to **claude.ai** and click **Sign up**. Use your email or your Google account.
2. Upgrade to **Pro** at **claude.com/pricing**. It is **$20/month** (or $17/month if you pay for a year up front).
3. That is it. The same login now works in the app, in VS Code, everywhere.

IMPORTANT: THE FREE PLAN WILL NOT WORK

Claude Code is not included in the free plan. You must be on **Pro** (or higher). If a screen later says "upgrade to continue," this step was missed.

2 Install VS Code (your workspace)

REQUIRED

VS Code is a free app from Microsoft. It is the window where we will build things all course. Download it from **code.visualstudio.com/download**, then follow your system below.

ON A MAC

1. Download the **Mac Universal** file (a **.dmg**).
2. Open the downloaded .dmg file.
3. Drag the **Visual Studio Code** icon into your **Applications** folder.
4. Open it from Applications (or Launchpad).

ON WINDOWS

1. Download the **Windows User Installer** (x64 for most PCs).
2. Double-click the downloaded **.exe** file.
3. Accept the agreement and click **Next** through the wizard, then **Finish**.
4. VS Code opens automatically.

3 Add Claude Code inside VS Code

REQUIRED

This puts your AI assistant right inside your workspace. No terminal, no coding tools to install.

1. In VS Code, click the **Extensions** icon on the left bar (the four little squares). *Or press Cmd+Shift+X on Mac, Ctrl+Shift+X on Windows.*
2. In the search box, type **Claude Code**. Pick the one by publisher **anthropic** and click **Install**.
3. Open a folder to work in: **File → Open Folder**, then create or pick an empty folder (for example, a new folder on your Desktop called **ai-course**).
4. Click the **Claude Code** icon (a spark, near the top right when a file is open, or the small icon in the bottom bar).
5. Click **Sign in**. A browser window opens. Log in with your account from Step 1 and approve. *Done. You are connected.*

IF IT EVER ASKS FOR AN "API KEY"

Do not enter one. Just choose **Sign in** and log in with your normal Claude account in the browser. API keys are a separate paid thing you do not need.

TOO MUCH? THE SIMPLEST POSSIBLE OPTION

If VS Code feels overwhelming, do this instead and you will still be ready: download the **Claude desktop app** from claude.com/download, install it, sign in, and click the **Code** tab. Claude Code is built in, nothing else to install. We will help you move into VS Code in class. **Windows users** who take this route: also install Git first (see the blue note below).

4 Check that it works

REQUIRED

A 20-second test so you walk into Session 2 confident.

1. In the Claude Code panel, type this and press Enter:
   Create a file called hello.txt that says "hello from [your name]".
2. Claude proposes a change. Click **Accept** (or Yes).
3. Look in your folder. If **hello.txt** is there, you are done.

You are ready for Session 2 when...

you can open Claude Code, type a request, and watch it do the thing. That is the whole finish line. Bring your laptop charged.

WINDOWS ONLY **One extra install:** so Claude Code can work smoothly with files and projects, install **Git for Windows** from git-scm.com/downloads/win. Download it, run the installer, and click Next through with the default options. Mac users already have this, nothing to do.

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

"Upgrade to continue" or Code will not open	You are on the Free plan. Go back to Step 1 and subscribe to Pro. That unlocks it.
It asks for an API key	Do not enter one. Choose Sign in and log in with your account in the browser instead.
I installed the extension but see nothing	Open a file or folder first (the icon only appears then). Then close and reopen VS Code.
A "command not found" message	You went down a harder path. Use the VS Code extension (Step 3) or the desktop app instead. No commands needed.
My work laptop blocks the install	Company laptops often block new apps or websites. Use a personal laptop if you can, or ask IT to allow claude.ai and VS Code.
It says my computer is too old	Claude Code needs macOS 13 or newer, or Windows 10 (2018 update) or newer. Check for a system update.
Not in a supported country	Claude is available in most, not all, countries. See anthropic.com/supported-countries. Tell me and we will find a workaround.

WANT TO TRY MORE? (OPTIONAL, NOT REQUIRED)

Only if you are curious. If Claude Code works, you already have everything you need for the course. These are extra playgrounds, not requirements.

Google Antigravity FREE

A full AI coding studio, free, that signs in with a normal Gmail account. The best zero-cost way to see an AI agent build and test something end to end. Download from **antigravity.google/download**, install like any app, and log in with Google. Works on Mac and Windows.

OpenAI Codex

Worth it **only if you already pay for ChatGPT**. In that case, open **chatgpt.com** and use Codex right there, nothing to install. Do not pay a second $20/month just for this if you already have Claude Code.

Stuck? Do not suffer in silence. Send me a message before Session 2 and we will get you set up. It is normal to hit one snag, that is what I am here for.

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